

BATTLESHIP

A complete three-page rulebook for the classic hidden-fleet strategy game

Battleship is a two-player deduction game in which each commander secretly deploys a fleet and tries to locate the opposing ships by calling grid coordinates. Every shot provides information. Good players combine careful record-keeping, probability, and misdirection rather than firing randomly.

AT A GLANCE

Players: 2 | Recommended age: 8+ | Playing time: 20-40 minutes | Objective: sink the entire opposing fleet before yours is destroyed.

1. COMPONENTS AND STANDARD FLEET

Each player needs one **ocean grid** for placing ships and one **targeting grid** for recording shots. A standard grid contains 100 squares arranged in ten columns labeled A-J and ten rows labeled 1-10. A coordinate combines one letter and one number, such as **C7**.

Ship	Length	Typical abbreviation
Carrier	5 squares	C
Battleship	4 squares	B
Cruiser	3 squares	Cr
Submarine	3 squares	S
Destroyer	2 squares	D

If your physical edition contains different ships or grid sizes, use the fleet printed in that edition. Both players must always receive identical fleets and agree on all variants before deployment.

2. GAME PREPARATION

2.1 Prepare the play area

- Sit opposite one another so that neither player can see the other ocean grid. Use screens, folders, or the lids of a commercial game set if necessary.
- Place all ships, hit markers, miss markers, and writing tools within reach. Decide who takes the first turn by a coin toss, agreement, or by alternating the first player between games.

2.2 Deploy the fleet

- Place each ship entirely inside your ocean grid. Every segment of a ship occupies exactly one square.
- Ships may be placed only horizontally or vertically. Diagonal ships, bent ships, and ships extending beyond the grid are illegal.
- Two ships may not overlap or share a square. Under standard rules they may touch side by side or at corners; players may instead agree on a no-touch variant.
- Once the first legal shot is called, ship locations are locked and may not be moved, rotated, exchanged, or removed.
- Before play begins, silently verify that all five ships are present with the correct lengths and that no square is occupied twice.

Fair-play check

Each player should be able to count exactly 17 occupied squares: 5 + 4 + 3 + 3 + 2. Do not reveal where those squares are.

3. CORE TURN SEQUENCE

Players alternate turns. In the standard single-shot game, one complete turn consists of the following steps:

- **Call a coordinate.** Clearly announce one unused square, for example "Fire at H6."
- **Resolve the shot.** The defender checks the ocean grid and answers "miss" if the square is empty or "hit" if it contains an unhit ship segment.
- **Record the result.** The attacker marks the targeting grid; the defender marks the affected square on the ocean grid. A common system uses X for a hit and O or a dot for a miss.
- **Announce a sinking.** If that shot hits the final intact segment of a ship, the defender says "You sank my Destroyer," naming the ship.
- **End the turn.** Unless a variant says otherwise, a hit does not grant an extra shot. The opponent now becomes the attacker.

BATTLESHIP: DETAILED PLAY AND VARIANTS

Shots, sinking, alternative modes, and complete edge-case rulings

4. HITS, MISSES, AND SUNK SHIPS

A shot is resolved only against the exact coordinate called. A nearby ship does not cause a hit. A damaged ship remains in its original position and continues occupying all of its squares. It is sunk only when **every** square belonging to it has been hit. Partial damage never reduces its size or changes its location.

The defender must report the result truthfully and promptly. In the standard transparent-information rule, the defender also names a ship when it sinks. The attacker may use that information to cross out the ship from the remaining fleet list. Players do not have to reveal unhit segments, direction, or surrounding water.

5. OPTIONAL PLAYING MODES

5.1 Salvo mode - shots based on surviving ships

At the start of a turn, count your ships that have not been sunk. You may call that many different coordinates as one salvo. With five surviving ships, call five shots; after losing two ships, call only three. The defender then reports each result in the same order. This mode rewards early damage because sinking an enemy ship reduces the enemy's future firepower.

- All coordinates in a salvo must be unique and announced before the defender gives results.
- Record every coordinate carefully so that the spoken results cannot be assigned to the wrong squares.
- If the final enemy ship is destroyed partway through a salvo, the game ends immediately; unused shots are irrelevant.

5.2 Fixed three-shot mode - easier information

Each player calls three different coordinates per turn, regardless of surviving ships. After each coordinate, the defender reports hit or miss and identifies a newly sunk ship. This resembles the easier rule shown in the supplied reference and creates a faster, more tactical game.

5.3 Fixed three-shot mode - harder information

The attacker calls three coordinates, and the defender reports only the total number of hits in the salvo, such as "two hits." The defender does not reveal which coordinates hit or which ships were struck, but must still announce a completely destroyed ship if the players want sinking information. The attacker marks all three shots as unresolved candidates or uses a special symbol. Because this variant creates ambiguity, both players should use the same recording method.

5.4 No-touch fleet variant

Ships may not occupy horizontally, vertically, or diagonally adjacent squares. After a ship sinks, every surrounding square is known water. This makes searching easier but deployment more constrained. Agree whether touching only at corners is also forbidden.

6. EDGE CASES AND OFFICIAL TABLE RULINGS

- **Repeated coordinate:** a square that was already resolved cannot be fired upon again. If the mistake is noticed before the defender answers, the attacker chooses another square. If the defender already answered, no new information was gained; replace the shot unless your pre-agreed tournament rule treats it as wasted.
- **Invalid coordinate:** a call outside A-J or 1-10 has no target. Correct it immediately before any result is given.
- **Ambiguous speech:** if B and D, or another letter, could be confused, repeat the coordinate using a clear word such as "B as in Bravo, seven." The defender should not resolve an unclear call.
- **Incorrect hit report:** stop as soon as the error is discovered. Correct both records, reconstruct later shots in order, and reverse only consequences caused by the mistake. If reconstruction is impossible, restart or mutually agree on a fair remedy.
- **Forgotten sunk announcement:** announce the sinking immediately when discovered and update the fleet lists. Previously resolved legal shots remain valid.
- **Two ships touching:** a hit at the boundary belongs only to the ship occupying that exact square. The defender must track the identity of every occupied square so that one hit is never credited to two ships.
- **Simultaneous final destruction in salvo mode:** the active player wins as soon as the opponent's last ship is destroyed. The defender's fleet does not return fire during the same turn.
- **Illegal setup found late:** if a ship overlaps, bends, or lies outside the grid, the owner forfeits under strict play. In a friendly game, pause and redeploy the illegal ship in a legal location without showing the opponent, then continue only if both players agree.
- **Accidental grid exposure:** cover the grid immediately. If important positions were seen, restart the game or allow the disadvantaged player to redeploy before further shots.
- **Running out of markers:** use pencil symbols or substitute tokens. The history of resolved coordinates must remain unambiguous.

7. END OF THE GAME

The game ends immediately when every segment of all enemy ships has been hit. The attacker who destroys the final surviving ship wins. Reveal both ocean grids and verify that placement and recorded results were legal. For a match, alternate the starting player and play an agreed odd number of games, such as best of three or best of five.

Example ruling

You call D6 and receive a hit. On later turns, C6 is a miss and E6 is another hit. The target must extend from D6 toward E6; diagonal squares cannot be part of that same ship. Continue along the row until the ship sinks or the line ends.

BATTLESHIP: STRATEGY, TRICKS, AND QUICK REFERENCE

Practical methods for searching efficiently, finishing targets, and avoiding predictable deployment

8. SEARCH STRATEGY - FINDING THE FIRST HIT

Use parity instead of random shots

Because the smallest standard ship occupies two adjacent squares, color the board mentally like a checkerboard and fire primarily on one color. Every legal ship of length two or more must cross that color. This roughly halves the opening search space without making any ship impossible to find. When only a larger ship remains, spacing shots even farther apart can be efficient, provided every possible placement still intersects a tested square.

Prefer high-probability squares

Central squares belong to more possible ship placements than corners. Early in the game, give slightly higher priority to central and near-central areas. After each miss, imagine every still-possible placement of each unsunk ship. Squares shared by many placements are stronger targets than isolated guesses.

Adapt to the remaining fleet

A two-space Destroyer can hide in small gaps that cannot contain a Carrier. If the Destroyer is already sunk, ignore gaps shorter than the smallest remaining ship. Conversely, when only the Destroyer remains, examine every adjacent untested pair rather than continuing a wide search pattern.

9. TARGET STRATEGY - CONVERTING A HIT INTO A SINK

- After the first hit, test the four orthogonally adjacent squares: left, right, above, and below. Diagonal squares cannot continue the same ship.
- Once a second aligned hit confirms the orientation, stop testing perpendicular squares and continue along both ends of the line.
- Use boundaries and previous misses. If one end reaches the edge or a known miss, attack only the open end.
- When ships may touch, do not assume every connected hit belongs to one ship. Use announced sinking and ship lengths to separate adjacent targets.
- After sinking a ship, return to search mode. Under no-touch rules, mark every surrounding square as water; under standard touching rules, those squares remain possible targets.

10. DEPLOYMENT TRICKS AND DEFENSIVE TIPS

- **Avoid obvious symmetry.** Fleets arranged in parallel rows, tidy blocks, or matching corners are easy to predict after the first discovery.
- **Mix orientations.** Use both horizontal and vertical ships so one successful sweep does not reveal the whole fleet.
- **Use edges selectively.** Edge ships have fewer directions from which they can be extended after a hit, but many opponents search the center first. Do not place every ship on an edge.
- **Separate some ships.** Clustering can cause several ships to be discovered during one target sequence. A scattered fleet makes each new search begin from limited information.
- **Break your own habits.** Across repeated games, rotate strategies. A technically legal layout becomes weak if the opponent recognizes your favorite positions.
- **Do not react physically.** Keep the same expression and pace for hits, misses, near misses, and dangerous coordinates. Unintentional reactions can reveal more than the official answer.

11. COMMON MISTAKES TO AVOID

- Failing to mark misses, which leads to repeated shots and destroys useful negative information.
- Continuing in search mode after a hit instead of testing adjacent squares.
- Guessing diagonally from a hit even though ships cannot be diagonal.
- Assuming a ship has sunk before the defender announces it.
- Forgetting which ships remain and searching gaps too small to contain them.
- Changing house rules during play. Variants must be agreed before fleets are placed.

12. QUICK REFERENCE CHECKLIST

Before the game	During every turn	When a ship sinks
Same fleet and grid size	Call an unused legal coordinate	Defender names the ship
Ships straight and non-overlapping	Defender reports truthfully	Both players update records
Variants agreed in advance	Both players mark the result	Attacker returns to search mode
17 occupied squares verified	Check whether a ship is sunk	Check whether the fleet is gone

Final reminder

Battleship is a game of incomplete information, not memory alone. Record every result, eliminate impossible placements, and make each new shot answer a useful question.